RAJASTHAN

The Doctor Is In... But Sans a Licence

MBBS graduates from abroad who can't pass the India exam are greasing their way in with forgery

By **Rohit Parihar**







DECEIVERS' GALLERY From top, Deepak Yadav, Raju Gurjar and Naresh Gurjar, accused in the fake FMGE certificate scam

IRREGULARITIES IN MEDICAL ENTRANCE TESTS are all over the news. But one kind has attracted far less attention. Medical graduates from foreign institutions seem to be systematically obtaining local registration without clearing the mandatory Foreign Medical Graduate Examination (FMGE) and allegedly beginning practice using fake certificates. The latest arrest, that of a 27-year-old MBBS graduate from Kazakhstan, has added another link to what investigators describe as a large network that offers the specialty of forged FMGE certificates.

The graduate in question, Nitin Kumar, allegedly paid Rs 10 lakh for a fake FMGE certificate after repeatedly failing the mandatory screening exam, says Vishal Bansal, additional director general, Special Operations Group (SOG). Using the forged document, he allegedly secured internship and provisional registration through the Rajasthan Medical Council (RMC). The investigation has resulted in 29 arrests, including that of former RMC registrar Dr Rajesh Sharma, brokers and 24 foreign graduates. Investigators say they have identified over 100 foreign graduates who allegedly got forged FMGE certificates and used them to secure registration in Rajasthan.

The biannual FMGE exam occupies a unique place in India's medical system. Every Indian citizen or Overseas Citizen of India who earns an MBBS degree abroad—barring a handful of countries—must clear this step before becoming eligible for registration and practice in India. Conducted by the National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences, it's widely regarded as one of India's toughest professional qualifying tests. In the FMGE held on June 28, only 13.5 per cent of the 37,448 candidates managed to qualify. Low success rates have been quite the trend. The highest pass percentage since June 2023 has been 29.62, the lowest 10.20.

Takeaways

- **Those who fail the Foreign Medical Grad. Exam (FMGE) sneak in using forged papers**
- **State medical councils, brokers collude to let them in**
- **FMGE has low pass ratios**

AN ECOSYSTEM OF FRAUD

A tough exam makes sense, but those low pass rates created a lucrative market for middlemen, who allegedly charge Rs 20-30 lakh for arranging forged certificates and facilitating registrations. The question is: how do these forged papers repeatedly clear official scrutiny within state medical councils (SMCs)? The SOG hints at the obvious: collusion.

Rajasthan is not the lone state facing this problem. Beginning December 2022, the CBI had probed the entire system involved in allowing sub-par foreign medical graduates between 2011 and 2022. Conducted across 14 states, the probe was to expose a vital chink in the national health infrastructure. Yet, there's little public information about whether any systemic reforms followed. Were all registrations granted during that period audited? Was a digital verification system created to authenticate certificates? Were audits conducted to ensure loopholes had been closed?

The recurrence of the problem suggests the cure has fallen to an endemic ailment: laxity, or worse. In March, Chhattisgarh reportedly launched an internal audit to verify 3,000 registrations. Compromised entrance exams rightly provoke outrage. Doctors with forged credentials should too. ■